SEBI GRADE A IT - EVENING-FIRST STUDY GUIDE

24 August - 30 November 2026 | Testbook-led practice | Phase-II-first

The key change: every study session starts after 7 PM. Phase II gets the main time because it drives final merit. Phase I is built in parallel so you reach November end with the whole syllabus covered and enough mock practice to clear it safely.

Important: this plan uses the latest completed official recruitment cycle as the baseline. The next notification can change dates or details; when SEBI releases the next notification, update the plan against that document.

1. The Rule for Every Topic: Exactly How to Start

Do **not** start with 100 random MCQs for a topic. For every topic, use the same six-step loop. This is the answer to “I have Testbook - where exactly do I practice?”

Step	What you do	Where
1. Learn - 25-40 min	Read/watch one small concept only.	Your textbook/Testbook study material or one trusted reference
2. Code - 15-25 min	Implement the basic operation/algorithm yourself.	VS Code / LeetCode / your C++ or Python editor
3. Topic Test - 20-30 min	Attempt 20-30 topic-wise questions timed.	Testbook -> SEBI Grade A IT -> topic-wise test / practice set
4. Error review - 15 min	Every wrong/guessed question gets a reason.	Testbook solution + your error notebook
5. Retest - 15-20 min	Redo wrong questions without seeing the solution.	Testbook reattempt/history + error notebook
6. Weekly mixed test	Mix old and new topics so recognition is tested.	Testbook -> sectional/mixed IT mock

Rule: one topic is “done” only when you can get 80-85%+ on a fresh topic test, explain the common traps, and solve representative code/implementation questions without notes.

Use Testbook in this order: **Study Material/Classes -> Topic Test/Practice Set -> Previous-Year/Memory-Based Questions -> Sectional Mock -> Full Mock.** Do not spend most of your time watching lectures once you understand the concept.

2. Data Structures - Use This Exact Practice Workflow

Topic	First learn	Then practice	Done condition
Arrays	1) Basics + complexity. 2) two pointers. 3) sliding window. 4) prefix sum. 5) intervals/matrix basics.	Code 5 patterns; Testbook 40-50 Q; 20 fresh mixed Q; 10 dry-runs.	Done at 85% topic accuracy + no repeated conceptual errors.
Linked List	Singly/doubly/circular; reverse; middle; cycle; merge; intersection.	Code 6 operations; Testbook 30-40 Q; 10 pointer traces.	Trace pointers on paper.
Stack/Queue	Implementations; circular queue; deque; priority queue; expression basics.	Code 4 implementations; Testbook 30-40 Q; 10 output traces.	Know overflow/underflow + complexity.
Binary Tree	Traversals; height; depth; full/complete/perfect; level order.	Code traversals; Testbook 40-50 Q; 15 tree traces.	Be able to trace recursion.
BST	Search/insert/delete; min/max; predecessor/successor; degeneration.	Code core ops; Testbook 30-40 Q; 10 output/trace Q.	Know average vs worst case.
Heap	Min/max heap; heapify; build heap; heap sort; priority queue.	Code insert/delete/heapify; Testbook 30-40 Q; 10 traces.	Memorize O(n) build-heap fact.
Hashing	Hash function; collision; chaining; probing; load factor; rehash.	Implement chaining + one probing scheme; Testbook 40 Q.	Know average vs worst-case.
Indexing	Dense/sparse, B/B+ tree, primary/secondary, clustered concepts.	Read one DB reference; Testbook 25-30 Q.	Focus on definitions + why.
Matrix	Transpose, rotate, spiral, diagonal, search, multiplication.	Code 8 patterns; Testbook 20-25 Q.	Keep implementation templates.
JSON	Objects, arrays, nesting, key/value, parsing, serialization.	Do 10 JSON validity/structure questions; Testbook 15-20 Q.	Focus on structure and interpretation.

3. Algorithms - How to Practice

Topic	First learn	Exact Testbook/Practice target
Sorting	Bubble, selection, insertion, merge, quick, heap; stability; in-place; best/avg/worst.	20 concept MCQ + 20 code/output + 20 comparison MCQ + 10 traces.
Searching	Linear, binary, lower/upper bound, answer-space binary search.	15 concept + 15 code-output + 10 traces.
Greedy	Activity selection, fractional knapsack, scheduling, Huffman, MST/Dijkstra concepts.	20 concept + 15 solution-selection + 10 traces.
DP	Recurrence -> memoization -> tabulation -> space optimization; knapsack, subsequence, grid, coin change.	40-60 targeted MCQ/problems; 15 recurrence/state traces.
Backtracking	Subsets, permutations, combinations, N-Queens, Sudoku, maze.	20 concept/code + 10 recursion-tree traces.
Divide & Conquer	Binary search, merge sort, quick sort, recurrence basics.	15 concept + 10 recurrence + 10 code-output.
Pattern Search	Naive, KMP/LPS, Rabin-Karp basics.	15 concept + 10 code/trace.

For algorithms, Testbook is not enough by itself: after the Testbook questions, code at least one representative implementation. SEBI-style questions can test logic completion, debugging, syntax and output, so pure MCQ familiarity is not sufficient.

4. OOP + Strings - High Return Areas

Topic	Study	Practice
OOP - Core	Abstraction, encapsulation, polymorphism, inheritance; overloading vs overriding.	Testbook 40-50 Q; 20 C++/Python code-output Q; explain each answer.
C++ OOP	Virtual function, pure virtual, virtual destructor, copy/move, Rule of 3/5, slicing, const.	Write 10 tiny programs; Testbook 30 Q; trace 10.
Python OOP	MRO, super(), multiple inheritance, class/static methods, ABCs, magic methods.	Write 8 tiny programs; Testbook 25-30 Q; trace 10.
Strings	Length, slicing, substring, frequency, search.	Testbook 30 Q + 15 implementation questions.
Regex	Classes, quantifiers, anchors, grouping, alternation, escaping, greedy/non-greedy.	Use Python regex tester/editor; then Testbook 20-30 Q.
Pattern search	Naive, KMP/LPS, Rabin-Karp basics.	Code one version; Testbook 20 Q + 10 traces.

Your language priority

Use **C++ as the primary implementation language** because you already code in C++. Use Python for regex, JSON, slicing, dictionaries/sets and Python OOP. The goal is to be language-confident enough to trace code, spot syntax/logic errors and reason about output.

5. The Daily Evening Timetable

Assumption: you are free after 7 PM and can study about 3 hours. The times can shift by 15-30 minutes; preserve the block lengths and sequence.

Time	Block	Exactly what to do
7:00-7:15	Warm-up review	10 old error-log questions + 5 complexity facts
7:15-8:00	Phase-II concept	One micro-topic from the week's syllabus; no topic hopping
8:00-8:35	Implementation / dry run	Code 1-3 small problems or trace 5-10 programs
8:35-9:05	Testbook topic test	20-30 timed questions; mark every guess
9:05-9:20	Break	No study
9:20-9:50	Testbook analysis	Read explanations; log every wrong/guessed answer
9:50-10:15	Phase-I block	Quant / Reasoning / English / GA rotation
10:15-10:30	English / current affairs	Read one article/editorial or write a mini paragraph
10:30-10:45	Retest	Redo today's wrong questions + 5 from last week

If you have only 2 hours

7:00-7:45 Phase-II concept/implementation -> 7:45-8:20 Testbook -> 8:20-8:50 analysis -> 8:50-9:10 Phase I -> 9:10-9:20 retest.

If you have 4 hours

Add 45 minutes between the Phase-II and Phase-I blocks for a second IT set or an English essay/precis. Do **not** add more lectures.

6. Weekly Evening Allocation

Day	7 PM onward	Primary objective
Monday	DS / concept + Testbook	New topic
Tuesday	DS / implementation + Testbook	Code and application
Wednesday	Algorithms + Testbook	New algorithm family
Thursday	Algorithms/OOP + Testbook	Code-output and theory
Friday	Strings/OOP + mixed IT	Consolidation
Saturday	Long study block + English	Topic tests + essay/precis
Sunday	Mock + analysis	Exam simulation

Sunday rule: the mock is followed by analysis. A 90-minute test with no analysis is only half a study session.

7. Week-by-Week Plan Through November

Phase-II core	Phase-I / English	Weekly target
Arrays	Baseline Paper-I + 2 mini English tasks	250 IT Q + 1 essay + 1 precis
Linked List + Stack/Queue	Reasoning + English + GA	250-300 IT Q + 2 essays
Trees + BST	Quant + IT Phase-I basics	300 IT Q + 1 essay + 1 precis
Heap + Hashing	Reasoning + GA	300 IT Q + mixed IT test
Indexing + Matrix + JSON	English + Quant	250 IT Q + 2 essays
Sorting + Searching	Phase-I IT + GA	300-350 IT Q + first full IT mixed mock
Greedy + Divide/Conquer	DBMS/SQL starts	300 IT Q + 2 essays
Dynamic Programming	Networking starts	300-350 IT Q + 1 precis + 1 mock
Backtracking + Pattern Search	Cyber + DBMS/SQL	300 IT Q + 3 essays
DS second pass	Networking + English	350 targeted Q + 1 full IT + 1 Phase-I mock
Algorithms second pass + OOP	Cyber + GA	350 Q + 1 Phase-II mock + 2 essays
OOP + Strings + weak topics	Finish Phase-I syllabus	300 targeted Q + 2 mocks
Full revision by weakness	Phase-I mock cycle	2 Phase-II mocks + 2 Phase-I mocks
Exam simulation	Final English/GA/Phase-I revision	3 Phase-II mocks + 2 Phase-I mocks
Audit only	No new topics	Error log + light mixed test

8. English - What to Practice and Where

For Phase II English, use one book for technique and Testbook for timed practice. Your goal is not to memorize model essays. It is to repeatedly produce clear, balanced answers under time pressure.

Task	Where to practice	Frequency
Essay	Arihant Descriptive English (SP Bakshi) for structure + Testbook/your own timed topics for actual writing	2/week Aug-Sep; 3/week Oct-Nov
Precis	Arihant + Testbook descriptive practice	1/week Aug-Sep; 2/week Oct-Nov
RC	Testbook descriptive/English sets + quality editorials	1/week Aug-Sep; 2-3/week Oct-Nov
Grammar	Objective General English SP Bakshi optional + Testbook Phase-I English	20-30 Q, 3 days/week
Vocabulary	Editorials + error notebook	10-15 min, 4 days/week

Essay topics to rotate

- AI in financial regulation; AI and employment; generative AI governance.
- Cybersecurity in financial markets; ransomware; digital fraud.
- Investor protection vs fintech innovation.
- Digital financial inclusion and India's digital public infrastructure.
- Data privacy vs convenience in digital finance.
- Algorithmic trading and market stability.
- Cloud adoption and resilience in regulated institutions.
- ESG disclosures, green finance and climate risk.
- Corporate governance and investor confidence.
- Financial literacy and investor protection.
- Balancing ease of doing business with regulatory compliance.
- Data analytics for detecting market manipulation.
- Open finance and financial privacy.
- Technology-driven regulation and supervisory challenges.
- Global shocks and resilience of Indian financial markets.

9. How to Read for Essay Content

Do not read current affairs like a GK student. Read them like an essay writer: **issue -> cause -> impact -> stakeholder -> policy/regulatory response -> risks -> way forward**.

Daily source	Time	What to extract
SEBI releases / circulars	10 min	What changed and why it matters
RBI releases / speeches	10 min	Policy/economic argument
One quality business editorial	15 min	Thesis + 2 opposing arguments
Weekend government/report reading	30-45 min	Data/examples + policy framing

Recommended reading domains

- Capital markets, investor protection, mutual funds, bonds, derivatives and IPOs.
- Fintech, UPI, digital lending, account aggregation, AI and privacy.
- Cybersecurity, resilience, digital identity and fraud.
- Inflation, growth, monetary/fiscal policy and financial inclusion.
- Corporate governance, disclosure, ESG and green finance.

Make a one-page “argument bank” for each major domain. One page should contain 5 arguments, 3 examples, 2 risks and 2 policy responses.

10. Phase-I Plan - Keep It Secondary but Finish by November

Block	Aug-Sep	Oct	Nov
Quant	25 Q x 3/week	35 Q x 3/week	2 sectionals/week
Reasoning	25 Q x 3/week	35 Q x 3/week	2 sectionals/week
English	20 Q x 3/week	30 Q x 3/week	1 full paper/week
GA/Financial Awareness	15-20 min x 4/week	20-25 min x 4/week	30 min x 5/week + revision
Phase-I IT	1-2 sessions/week	2 sessions/week	3 sessions/week + mocks
Mock	Sectional baseline	1/week	2/week

Phase-I IT-only syllabus gaps

After the Phase-II core is strong, complete DBMS/SQL, programming concepts, Python/R analytics, networking, cyber security, data warehousing and shell programming. For SQL, do actual query writing, not only MCQs.

Phase-I target: by November end, every topic has been seen once, major weak areas have been retested, and full mocks consistently clear minimum cutoffs with a buffer.

11. Mock and Retest System

When	What	How to review
Topic completed	20-30 Q topic test	Target 80-85%; review all misses/guesses
48-72 hours later	10-15 reattempt questions	No notes
1 week later	20 mixed questions	Include older topics
2-3 weeks later	Sectional test	Check retention
Every Sunday from Oct	Full/major mock	Analyze accuracy, time, silly errors

Error log columns

Question	Topic	Mistake type	Why wrong	Correct rule	Retest date	Retest result

Your most valuable questions are the ones you get wrong twice. Those deserve handwritten revision and a third retest.

12. Books and Resources - Do Not Overbuy

Resource	Use	Priority
Testbook subscription	Main practice platform: topic tests, previous-year/memory-based questions, sectionals, mocks	ESSENTIAL - already owned
Arihant Descriptive English by S.P. Bakshi	Essay, précis, comprehension/descriptive practice	BUY - one main English book
Objective General English by S.P. Bakshi	Phase-I grammar/objective practice	Optional if grammar needs work
Your existing DSA/Striver material	Implementations + interview-style problems	Use for coding, not as the sole SEBI source
Official SEBI notification/handouts	Syllabus/pattern authority	Always primary

Do not buy: a separate book for every DSA topic, a giant current-affairs book months in advance, or multiple overlapping English books. The extra time should go to Testbook practice and retesting.

13. Your “Array” Example - From Zero to Done

This is the model to follow for every subsequent topic.

Session	What you do
Day 1 - 7:15 PM	Learn arrays: complexity, indexing, insertion/deletion, contiguous memory.
Day 1 - 8:00 PM	Code traversal, max/min, reverse, insertion/deletion.
Day 1 - 8:35 PM	Testbook: Arrays topic-wise 20-30 questions, timed.
Day 1 - 9:20 PM	Review every wrong/guessed question; add 3-5 rules to error log.
Day 1 - 10:30 PM	Redo 5 wrong questions without looking.
Day 3	Take another 10-15 array questions from Testbook; target 80%+.
Day 7	Mixed DSA set containing arrays + linked list + stack; no array-only cues.
Day 14-21	Repeat a mixed test. If accuracy <85%, reopen the weak subtopic.
Done	Only after you can explain complexity, solve representative code, and score 85%+ on a fresh set.

Apply exactly the same sequence to linked lists, trees, heap, hashing, sorting, DP, OOP and strings.

14. November 30 Final Targets

- [ ] Phase-II IT: all official topics completed twice.
- [ ] Phase-II IT: 3,500-4,500 high-quality MCQs attempted, with wrong/guessed questions reattempted.
- [ ] Code tracing/debugging/syntax: 1,000+ short exercises or an equivalent volume.
- [ ] DSA complexity table memorized.
- [ ] OOP code-output questions comfortable in C++ and Python.
- [ ] English: 20-24 essays, 20 precis, 12-16 RC sets, 4+ full descriptive simulations.
- [ ] Phase-I: full syllabus covered, including DBMS/SQL, networking, cyber, data warehousing and shell gaps.
- [ ] Phase-I: 8-10 sectional/full mocks completed.
- [ ] Phase-II: at least 5 full/major mocks completed and analyzed.
- [ ] All repeated errors are in the error log and have been retested.
- [ ] Current affairs notes are organized by issue, not by date alone.

The finish line is not “I have watched everything.” It is “I can answer unfamiliar questions accurately, quickly, and explain why the wrong options are wrong.”

Official reference: SEBI Grade A 2025 recruitment advertisement and handouts. Re-check the next notification when released because the next cycle may change details.